Notes on Reading by Lamplight

Reading by the light of a single lamp changes the way a page feels. The edges of the room fall away, and the lines of text become the only landscape left to explore.

The Shape of a Line

Every line of type asks the eye to make a small journey from left to right, then a longer return sweep back to the start of the next line. Readers rarely notice these movements, yet they account for much of the effort that a long evening of reading requires.

A careful typesetter avoids breaking words across lines, but sometimes a long word such as extraor-
dinary has to be split to keep the right edge even. The mind of the reader simply mends the gap without being asked.

Short paragraphs give the eye a place to rest.

Keeping Your Place

When the eye loses its place, it wanders back over words it has already read. A strong start to each word gives it something to hold on to, the way a handrail steadies a walker on a dark stair.

The lighthouse keeper, a quiet man named Jean-Paul Marchand, kept a log of every ship that passed his tower. He wrote in a small, even hand and never skipped a night.

His log listed three things for each vessel:

- the hour it was first sighted,
- the direction of its wake,
- and the colour of its lamps.

Years later, readers of the log said it was the steadiness of the entries, more than any single story, that kept them turning the pages.

A Quiet Ending

Good reading light is warm, steady and placed slightly behind the shoulder, so that no glare rises from the paper and the words stay sharp until the last line.

The final sentence of this article should appear exactly once in the extracted text.